EMUNOT VEDEOT: SAADIAH GAON'S BOOK OF BELIEFS AND OPINIONS

Only God Is One: Why a Life Needs Balance

Given Monday 17 November 2025 · Emunot VeDeot, Essay 10:1-3

Sefer: Emunot VeDeot (The Book of Beliefs and Opinions) by Rav Saadia Gaon

Essay/Chapters: Essay 10 (How a Person Should Conduct Himself in This World), Introduction and Chapters 1 to 3, with the opening of Chapter 4

Shiur: Part of Dayan Daniel Kada's Monday series on Emunot VeDeot, Monday 17 November 2025, on Zoom

These notes are based on a transcript of the recording.

Recap: Saadia's Olam HaBa in One Picture

Last week the class finished the ninth essay. Before opening the tenth, the Rabbi drew together everything Saadia said about the World to Come:

- **A physical place.** Olam HaBa is a new world, inhabited by human beings made of **body and soul together**.
- **Light and fire.** The righteous enjoy the bliss of a light, which is what we call Olam HaBa or Gan Eden. The wicked suffer in its burning heat, which is Gehinom.
- **No time,** except when we need it to serve Hashem, and it is **eternal**, both the reward and the punishment.
- **Levels.** There are seven levels. Those with more and greater merits receive a more intense light; those with more and greater sins, a more intense fire.
- **Who sees whom.** Tzaddikim may see each other, but only those close to one another in level. Resha'im cannot see each other. The tzaddikim see the resha'im and think how fortunate they are; the resha'im see the tzaddikim and think how unfortunate they are.
- **Continued service of Hashem,** through prayer, and continued free choice, although Olam HaBa will only contain those whom Hashem knows will only choose correctly.

"Various of these points are very debatable. Some of them are quite difficult to accept and to understand, but we're learning Saadia Gaon." The Rambam, the Rabbi said, would argue with almost all of it apart from eternity: for him it is not body and soul, not light and heat, not a place at all, since nothing there is physical, and there is certainly no service of Hashem. The idea of continued service in Olam HaBa "is certainly very peculiar to Saadia, and no one else really says that."

Mark's question: the 51 per cent person

Mark asked about someone who is 51 per cent good and 49 per cent bad. According to Saadia he is a tzaddik. He suffers for his sins in this world, receives eternal good, and sits on a very low level, but he has no Gehinom at all. "There's only two categories": tzaddik, from 50 upwards, and rasha, below 50. The case of exactly 50-50 was dealt with about a year ago, in the earlier essay on merits,

where Hashem tips the scale towards kindness. "But again, how many people are we going to have who are exactly 50?"

Essay 10: The Appendix to the Sefer

The class began Emunot VeDeot in January 2024, and with Hashem's help will finish a little into January, two years exactly from the start.

The first nine essays fall into three sections, all of them philosophical:

Essays	Theme
The opening essays	**Hashem**
The middle essays	**Revelation**, mitzvot and aveirot
The final essays	**Reward and punishment** and eschatology: Mashiach, Techiyat HaMeitim and Olam HaBa

Saadia closes the sefer with a tenth essay, which the Rabbi called "really an appendix": **במה הטוב לאדם לעשותו בעולמו הזה**, what is the best way for a person to live his life in this world.

Saadia the man

"You get to see Saadia a bit more personally here, because he talks here about life." The essay has nineteen short chapters, and the Rabbi planned to move through them quickly. Its theme is **balance**, and it shows how widely Saadia ranged. The penultimate chapter is entirely about music, and how music too must be balanced.

The class has met this theme before: in Chovot HaLevavot some years ago, and last year in the Rambam's Shemonah Perakim. The Rambam is famous for the golden mean, which comes from Aristotle, "but Saadia echoes this completely." Saadia was himself a balanced person:

- the first to write a structured philosophical book on Judaism, "a huge groundbreaking work," which is why the Rabbi chose it: it lays the foundations for so much that the Rambam writes later;
- an expert in **astronomy**, as the class has seen;
- an expert in **mathematics** (recall the chapter on numbers);
- a grammarian, who wrote a book on **dikduk** and a lexicon.

"He's well-rounded, and that's the point he's trying to make in this essay."

The plan of the essay

- **Chapters 1 to 3:** an introduction to the concept of balance.
- **Chapters 4 to about 17:** thirteen areas of life that people take to an extreme, the dangers of each extreme, and the correct path.
- **The end:** balance in life in general, including music.

The Introduction: The Creator Is One, His Works Are Many

The Hebrew translation is by **Yehudah ibn Tibbon**, who opens, *Amar Yehudah ben Shaul*, before Saadia's own words.

הקדמת המאמר הזה שדיברו בו אנשים רבים ומעט מי שהגיע בו אל העצה המשובחת

This is a subject on which many people have spoken, but few have reached the praiseworthy conclusion.

Step 1: Hashem's unity requires multiplicity in creation

כי בורא הכל יתברך מפני שהיה אחד בעצמו התחייב שיהיו נבראים רבים

Because the Creator is One in Himself, it follows that His creations are many. The class saw this at the very start of the sefer. The Rabbi added a midrash to the same effect: Hashem created Chava as well as Adam because you cannot have one God and one human.

Step 2: Nothing we call "one" is really one

Anything we see as one is only one **בדרך המספר**, numerically. Examine it carefully and you find it is many.

- **The elements.** Every body contains the four qualities of medieval science, heat, cold, moisture and dryness. "Nowadays we would substitute that for protons, neutrons, electrons."
- **A tree** has branches, leaves and fruit.
- **A human** has flesh, bones, sinews, veins and tendons.
- **A chair** (the Rabbi's example) is one chair only "to the exclusion of two." In itself it is wood, plastic, atoms, protons and neutrons.

"This is before he knows about atoms, protons, neutrons and electrons, right? But this really is true today."

Step 3: This is a law of creation

כי הבורא אחד ומעשיו רבים

The Creator is One, and His works are many.

As Tehillim says, **מה רבו מעשיך ה' כולם בחכמה עשית**. Even the heavens are not one: they have different parts and measures, shapes, sights and signs beyond counting, as Iyov says, **עושה עש כסיל וכימה וחדרי תימן**.

"Okay, so what? Why is this relevant to the conduct of a human being?" Because, as Chapter 1 will say, the same applies to a person's traits. "Only God is one." It is never good to take one trait and hone in on it.

Chapter 1: A Person Should Not Live by One Trait

What are *ahavot*?

Saadia says the same is true of **אהבות**, literally "loves": **אהבה לדברים ושנאה לדברים**, love for things and hatred for things. The Rabbi admitted he struggled to translate it. Some render it as *hanhagot*, modes of conduct. It means the pull towards doing something or away from it. As Mishlei says, **רבות מחשבות בלב איש ועצת ה' היא תקום**: there are many things in a person's heart.

Just as bodies are not made of one element, a tree is not one part and a man is not only flesh, and the heavens are not in one place:

כן האדם לא יתנהג כל ימיו במידה אחת

So too a person should not conduct himself all his days by a single trait.

"This is his key point." Instead a person should gather them together, **רוב מדבר אחד ומעט מאחר**, more of one and a little of another. When he balances all the aspects of his identity correctly, **ישלם לו תיקון ענייניו**, his affairs are put right. It is as if he had brought them to judgment, **יכלכל דבריו במשפט**, or weighed them on a scale and divided them into portions, **פלס מעגל רגלך**.

Even what we think of as bad traits should not be negated completely. "You have to utilize everything which God has given us as part of our identity." The Rabbi noted that this is the idea the Rambam lays out in Hilchot Deot two hundred years or more later, but Saadia is one of the first of the Chachamim to state it explicitly and elaborate on it: "there is nothing bad and there's nothing only good."

Why Saadia needs to say this

הוא שראיתי אנשים חושבים... כי חובה שיתנהג האדם במידה אחת כל ימיו

Saadia saw people who believed one should live one's whole life by a single trait: raising one love above all others, or one hatred above all others. The Rabbi's illustration: "you get some people who are always talking about one specific kind of sin. That's not good." Saadia's verdict: **והנה היא מתכלית הרעות כולם**, this is the worst of all approaches.

His arguments:

1. **Hashem gave us many feelings.** If Hashem wanted us to work on only one thing, He would not have given us all these different emotions and traits.
2. **He would have made us from one element.** "Why do we have the bones, and the sinews, and the muscles?" Hashem made us with multiplicity to show us that life is nuanced.
3. **Nothing built from one material works.** A house built only from stones, or only from wood, or only from nails, is not as sound as one built from all of them together.
4. **The same is true of food, drink, clothing and everything else.** Anything in excess is harmful. "Even too much water can kill you."

If everything around us is made of many parts, **כל שכן ענייני נפשו ומידותיה**, how much more so a person's own soul and character.

Mark's question: generalist or specialist?

Mark asked whether Saadia means only character traits, or whether he is promoting being a generalist over a specialist. The Rabbi answered by previewing the thirteen areas (listed below in Chapter 4). They are not really *midot*: "Eating and drinking is not a tendency." They are "thirteen different important fundamental aspects of life" that people take to an extreme. So the essay is broader than character: it is also about balance in our ambitions, our goals and our enjoyment of this world.

Another participant asked whether anyone actually *desires* abstinence. "They don't desire it, they do it." It is an approach some people have thought is the best way to live. "Nobody desires to live a life of abstinence."

Chapter 2: The Damage of Extremes, and the Rule of the Intellect

Extremism is not a small matter

וצריך שאבאר כי חדושי הבחירה הזאת אין דעתם מעוטה, אך היא גדולה

Saadia gives examples of what a single-minded path does to people:

Extreme	Result
Those who chose to wander in the **mountains** (living as hermits)	It drove them to **madness**
Those who chose **much eating**	It brought them to **haemorrhoids**
Those who chose **revenge**	They took revenge on themselves

On the hermits: "This was quite a common thing, because all the Rishonim talked about it." Saadia, the Rambam, Rabbeinu Bachya and the Kuzari all discuss Jews who went to live alone and cut themselves off from the world, a tendency the Rabbi thought originated with the Christians. They took *perishut*, which is an important part of life, to an extreme.

On food: the person whose life is about the best pleasures, a new restaurant every week, "this kind of meat, eaten this way."

On revenge: "these are normally toxic people," who spend their whole life trying to right every wrong done to them. "You end up wronging yourself, you end up living the worst life."

That is why, Saadia says, we always need wisdom in how we conduct ourselves, **בהתהלכך תנחה אותך**.

The root principle: a person rules his traits

שהאדם מושל במידותיו ושולט במה שיאהב וישנא

A person is master of his traits and in control of what he loves and hates.

כי לכל אחד ממה שהוא אוהב ושונא מקום ורשות: every trait, including the ones we see as bad or impure, has its place. "Even revenge has a place sometimes." The Gemara says a talmid chacham who does not take revenge like a snake is not a talmid chacham.

- When you see the right place for a trait, **ישלחנה בשיעור שישלים מעשה ההיא**: use it in the amount the situation needs.
- When you see a place where it does not belong, **ויעצרנה**: hold it back.

This is only possible for someone who lives with **יישוב**, with self-possession, "not with impulses." As Mishlei says, **טוב ארך אפים מגיבור ומושל ברוחו מלוכד עיר**: better the slow to anger than the mighty, and one who rules his spirit than one who captures a city. "You need to have strong self-discipline and strong self-restraint to be able to live the best life."

The three faculties of the soul

Saadia reminds us of what he taught in the essay on the soul. The soul has three faculties:

Faculty	What it drives
כח התאוה (desire)	Food, drink and intimacy; looking at beautiful sights, smelling pleasant scents, touching soft things
כח הכעס (emotion, passion)	Seeking dominion and status, relying on others, revenge, arrogance and brazenness
כח ההכרה (cognition)	**ידין על כוחות האחרים**: it judges the other two

Whenever a person is faced with a choice, he should begin with cognition and examine it. If he sees that its end is free of harm, and all the more so if its end is praiseworthy, let him do it. If he sees significant harm on one side, let him leave it, "because my cognition is in control of my desire."

והמשיל הכרתו על תאוותו וכעסו, הרי הוא במוסר החכמים

One whose cognition rules his desire and his anger lives by the discipline of the wise, as it says, **יראת ה' מוסר חכמה**. One whose desire and anger rule his cognition is not a man of discipline at all. And if he calls that his ethic, "follow the dreams of your heart, people say," Saadia calls it **מוסר אוילים**, "the musar of idiots."

The Rabbi: "Deep down we know this. We only make mistakes, we only do wrong things because we don't think this through." A person who loses his temper says, I'm sorry, I lost control. "You let your *ka'as*... reign over your cognition." Cognition knows "you never get anything out of anger. Anger never works." The same with someone who eats something forbidden: "they know it's wrong, but the desire has trumped the cognition."

Melech and Kalem

The Rabbi brought a teaching he heard from **Rav Moshe Shapiro** zt"l. Why is a king, at least a king of old, looked up to? Because he is in control. **מלך** is an acronym for **מוח, לב, כבד**: brain, heart, liver.

1. **Moach:** the brain decides this is right.
2. **Lev:** the heart then builds up a passion and desire for it, because the brain said so.
3. **Kaved:** the liver, the blood, the person himself carries it out in action.

The Gemara in Berachot says that Bilam tried to curse Bnei Yisrael at the one moment when Hashem's anger is present. How long is that moment? **אחד מחמשת רבוא ושמונת אלפים ושמונה מאות ושמונים ושמונה חלקים בשעה**, one part in 58,888 of an hour. Tosafot asks what anyone could possibly say in so short a time, and gives two answers:

- **Once you begin at the right time, you may continue.** The Rabbi noted that some poskim learn from this that if you begin the Amidah before *sof zman tefillah*, it counts even if you finish after. It is disputed, and it is better to finish in time.
- **You can say one word: כלם**, "annihilate them."

Now look at the letters of **כלם**: they are **מלך** reversed. "So that's the biggest curse," that a person lives *kaved, lev, moach*: he acts, then desires, then rationalises it in his brain afterwards. Most of us, when we do wrong, know we are doing wrong. "It's not fine... we've lapsed." But the worst is to use our actions and desires to persuade the mind "that this is the best way to live," which means living the opposite of the correct life.

Chapter 3: Shlomo HaMelech's "Hevel"

Saadia now shows that **Shlomo HaMelech** taught the same thing in Kohelet.

ראיתי את כל המעשים שנעשו תחת השמש והנה הכל הבל ורעות רוח

It cannot be that Shlomo meant the world itself is vain, because Hashem created it. "How on earth could King Solomon say about God that He's created something which is vain?" Rather:

כי כל מעשה שיקחו בני אדם לבדו... יהיה הבל ורעות רוח

Any single activity a person takes up **alone**, to the exclusion of all else, is *hevel*. This is also the meaning of **מעוות לא יוכל לתקון**: each thing on its own is crooked and lacking, but **בהתחברותם**, joined together, they are complete.

The Rabbi called this "a chiddush, by the way." The normal understanding is that everything is vain. Saadia says no: things taken alone are vain; in combination they are good.

Three examples from Kohelet

Saadia explains *hevel* as something worthless or misleading, citing **מהבלים המה אתכם** and **ובגזל אל תהבלו**. Then he shows that Shlomo tried three things to their limit and declared each one *hevel*:

What Shlomo pursued alone	The verse	Why it fails
Wisdom	**ונתתי את לבי לדעת חכמה**	**יוסיף דעת יוסיף מכאוב**: the more you know, the more pain you see
Joy and laughter	**לכה נא אנסכה בשמחה וראה בטוב**	In the end a person feels lowered, as if he has entered the traits of animals: **לשחוק אמרתי מהולל**
Building up the world	**הגדלתי מעשי, בניתי לי בתים, נטעתי לי כרמים**	**שאניחנו לאדם שיהיה אחרי**: you will die and leave it all to someone else

On wisdom the Rabbi said, "This is a point which I think some of us can identify with. Sometimes the more simple a person is, the more naive a person is, the less problems they see with the world." The more you study and understand, the more of the world's problems you see. It is not good to study and study "and not be part of the world." On laughter he noted the word is *meholal*, from *hollelut*: "It's crazy, people who are always looking for leisure."

Having shown these three, Shlomo did not need to go through every other area. He was hinting that one should combine them, **ושיתעסק במעט מן החכמה**, a little wisdom, a little pleasure and a little building of the world, as he said, **תרתי בלבי למשוך ביין את בשרי**: sometimes one should enjoy wine as well.

"You need a combination of work, of leisure, and of study, all three together. And then it's not *hevel*."

Opening Chapter 4: The Thirteen Paths

Saadia announces his plan: to gather thirteen roots, which **Rav Kafih** translates as thirteen *derachim*, paths. For each he will explain what led people to choose it to the exclusion of all else, what they left out, and the correct place and measure for it.

הפרישות: abstinence, asceticism

האכילה: eating and drinking

המשגל: intimacy

החשק: passionate love

הבנים: children ("having a lot of DNA after you")

הישוב: building and cultivating the world

החיים: long life. "Some people, they always tell you about how healthy they are... but what are you doing with your life?"

הממון: accumulating money

השררה: dominion, status and authority

הנקמה: revenge, always righting the wrongs done to you

העבודה: work, more and more of it

החכמה: wisdom, pursuing more and more of it

המנוחה: rest and tranquility

Saadia then begins: *V'omer harishon*, the first is abstinence. That is where the class will pick up, together with other Rishonim, such as Rabbeinu Bachya's chapter on *perishut*.

Summary

1. **Saadia's Olam HaBa:** a new physical world of body and soul, light for the righteous and fire for the wicked, eternal, in seven levels, with continued service of Hashem. The Rambam disagrees with almost all of it.
2. **Essay 10** is the appendix to the sefer, on how to live in this world, and it shows Saadia the man: theologian, astronomer, mathematician and grammarian.
3. **Only God is one.** Everything else, even what we call one, is many. So a person should not live by a single trait.
4. **Building a life is like building a house:** stones alone or wood alone will not hold. Every trait has its place and its measure, even revenge.
5. **Cognition must rule desire and emotion.** That is the discipline of the wise; the reverse is "the musar of idiots." Melech, *moach lev kaved*, is the right order; *kalem* is its reverse.
6. **Kohelet's "hevel"** refers to any single pursuit taken alone: wisdom, pleasure or building. Combined, they are good.
7. **Thirteen paths** to be examined, starting next week with abstinence.

Coming Up

- **Next week, same time (6:00 to 7:00):** Chapter 4 onwards, starting with *perishut*, with the views of other Rishonim.
- **Tomorrow (Tuesday):** the Rambam shiur continues, beginning the Thirteen Principles of Faith with Principle 1.

Watch or listen to this shiur: youtu.be/H21dgn-dQnE · More shiurim: rabbikada.com